

stopped trading on the NYSE from October 28.

Shortly before the deal went through, Musk had hinted at overturning all lifetime bans, indicating a possible return of Trump to the platform. But, just a day before the buyout, on October 27, he addressed a note to 'Twitter Advertisers' saying: "Twitter obviously cannot become a free-for-all hellscape, where anything can be said with no consequences! In addition to adhering to the laws of the land, our platform must be warm and welcoming to all, where you can choose your desired experience according to your preferences." He also observed that social media in general runs the risk of be-

over, reports emerged that he had ordered Twitter engineers to ship a paid verification feature for blue-tick users by November 7. Existing verified users who don't upgrade in 90 days stand to lose their blue ticks. Musk's plan to charge approximately \$20 a month for verification badges came under the scanner immediately. As of November 2, Musk revised the subscription offering to \$8 per month, justifying the price users need to pay.

Twitter Blue subscribers "will get priority in replies, mentions and search, which is essential to defeat spam/scam; ability to post long video and audio; half as many ads and paywall bypass for publishers willing to work with us... There will

mainly advertising-driven until now, subscriptions could improve Twitter's margins, reckons the new boss. On October 31, Musk even launched a Twitter poll seeking views on whether he should "bring back Vine"? Vine was a short-video app, which Twitter acquired in 2012 but shut it down in 2016 for failing to monetise it. Now, with Musk's renewed focus on revenue streams for content creators, Vine could very well see a return as a separate app or an in-app integration within Twitter.

In the weeks leading up to the buyout, the Tesla chief had also hinted at his desire to turn Twitter into "X, the everything app". X could stand for a super app modelled



THE INDIA CONNECT

Sriram Krishnan, a well-known product expert in Silicon Valley, is helping out Elon Musk to fix things at Twitter. Krishnan is a General Partner at Andreessen Horowitz (also known as a16z), one of the largest venture capital firms in Silicon Valley. "I (and a16z) believe this is a hugely important company and can have great impact on the world and Elon is the person to make it happen," he tweeted, saying he is helping out Musk 'temporarily' and that his 'day job' remains at the investment firm. Chennai-

born Krishnan, who graduated from Anna University's SRM Engineering College, is not new to Twitter. He had a stint with the company in 2017-2019, when he led the core consumer product teams and launched several products, including a redesigned events feature. He helped Twitter grow its user base by over 20 per cent in about two years, Krishnan's LinkedIn profile says. He has also worked with tech giants Meta (Facebook), Snap and Microsoft in the past.

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ing "splintered into far right-wing and far left-wing echo chambers".

So, what can Musk do to prevent Twitter from becoming a more divisive platform than it already is? Soon after the acquisition, he announced that the San Francisco-based company would be forming a 'Content Moderation Council' and "no major content decisions or account reinstatements will happen before that council convenes". He added that the council will have "widely diverse viewpoints", without disclosing any further details.

Musk also does not want Twitter to be 'free' for all. Soon after the take-

be a secondary tag below the name for someone who is a public figure, which is already the case for politicians," he explained in a thread.

This essentially means that anyone with purchasing power can now be Twitter-verified, raising critical questions on the identity and authenticity of users. Several people have raised concerns over fake profiles with blue ticks, impersonation, and other cybercrimes. Musk, of course, has no plan of action yet to tackle these.

It is evident that Musk is keen on growing the share of subscriptions in Twitter's overall revenue pie. Pri-

on China's WeChat, which the West has failed to replicate so far. Twitter could potentially enable multiple services besides microblogging—from messaging and shopping to travel and payments—becoming a one-stop shop for users. While that might benefit its ad monetisation, spammy feeds and cluttered UIs could lead to a user exodus.

Musk's litmus test would be to grow Twitter, while simultaneously ensuring its loyal user base is retained. Can he succeed? Only time will tell. **BT**

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